

EVERYONE'S NAZIA
Pakistani Nazia Hassan was the spark that kindled Indipop



Breaking the Sound Barrier

New singing stars strike a popular note

FROM THE ARCHIVES
Apr. 30, 1989

Music
Hindi Pop: Breaking the Sound Barrier

Giant video screens flash her face, magnifying her babyish charms. A live orchestra belts out the rhythmic beat. Teenagers yell and clap. Her gestures are familiar as she discards her jewellery and tosses it at the audience with the same hurtful abandon and asks: "Do you want more?"

But it isn't Madison Square Garden, it is Rang Bhavan. The pop star isn't Madonna, it is Alisha Chinai. And the songs aren't in English, but in Hindi... Rickshaw drivers, Ganpati procession dancers, maidservants, even elderly couples, and, of course, teenagers have simultaneously discovered Hindi pop music.
–Salil Tripathi



"New singers now want to be pop artistes rather than playback singers. Pop gives them an identity which playback singing doesn't"

— ALISHA CHINAI

DID YOU KNOW?

In 1998, Magnasound paid Daler Mehndi Rs 2.75 crore for a two-year contract, the biggest ever single deal for a singer in India's history

Nazia's voice was sampled in Vishal–Shekhar's 'The Disco Song' for Karan Johar's *Student of the Year*, the debut film of Alia Bhatt

India's music industry had for decades been a protectorate of its song-laden cinema. Only a few non-film niches survived on the edges: classical, devotional et al. "*Disco Deewane* came like a breath of fresh air in that market," says Atul Churamani, co-founder of record label Magnasound. "It saw a peak in interest from local labels like HMV and Music India in non-film music." The cascading effect went in all directions. The title track—tossed in at the last minute, by music industry lore—explicitly referenced 'disco'. This gave a name to the fever that would grip the nation in the Eighties, filtering back to films, with Bappi Lahiri creating the memorable OST to *Disco Dancer* with classics like 'Jimmy Jimmy', even old-timers Kishore Kumar and Lata Mangeshkar jiving to 'Disco 82', and a long comet's tail with blinking lights thereon. The word would enter the Indian lexicon, marking out a revelrous party zone for ever-wider circles but also proverbially signifying anything hip, happy and modern. Soon, even subziwallahs were classifying their papayas into two types: desi and disco!

The genre Nazia-Biddu inaugurated—and amped up with *Boom Boom*—had enough élan vital to demand and acquire its own independent, sovereign territory. Filmi *gaana* wasn't about to be muted, of course, even if it mutated. The 'old is gold' anthology still ruled the AIR waves. Doordarshan wouldn't let Indian pop much into the room either, but it midwifed the revolution by giving wide play to the Grammies and the like: Michael Jackson & Co. ended up inflecting mass Indian tastes way more than '70s disco. And Indian epigones found a home on DD Metro's *Pop Time*—a shortlived half-hour show that showcased 'Western music with an Indian accent'. A glut of new artists filled the new niche: Sharon Prabhakar, the bustling rock 'n roll refugee Remo Fernandes, and going on to